

“French accomplices” and, most importantly, the independence of a democratic, progressive Vietnam. Tactically, they avoided mentioning communism or revolution.

Rival Vietnamese nationalist groups enjoyed more support from the Kuomintang, but it was the Viet Minh that built a network of clandestine cells in Vietnam. In late 1944, Ho’s colleague Vo Nguyen Giap began to form the Vietnam Armed Propaganda and Liberation Brigade: a fledgling guerrilla army, poorly armed and confined to the remotest areas of the country.

On March 9, 1945, fearing an Allied invasion of Indochina, the Japanese carried out a coup against the French authorities. Easily overcoming the French army, they announced an end to the colonial era. Cambodia and Laos were declared independent under their monarchs, as were Annam and Tonkin under Vietnamese emperor Bao Dai. In the absence of French troops, Giap’s Viet Minh guerrillas were now able to operate in the Viet Bac region, north of Hanoi. Wary of the Japanese, however, the Viet Minh bided their time, and made few raids upon the occupying forces. They eagerly anticipated a Japanese defeat, which would at last mean the possibility of Vietnam achieving genuine independence.